The Meaning of Crafts

✨ *team whimsy* ✨



Who are we

✨ *team whimsy* ✨



Jia
BS Design
MS HCI



Elsa
BS Design
MS HCI



Ahyan
BS Computer Science



Kelly
BS HCI
MS AI

Domain we chose





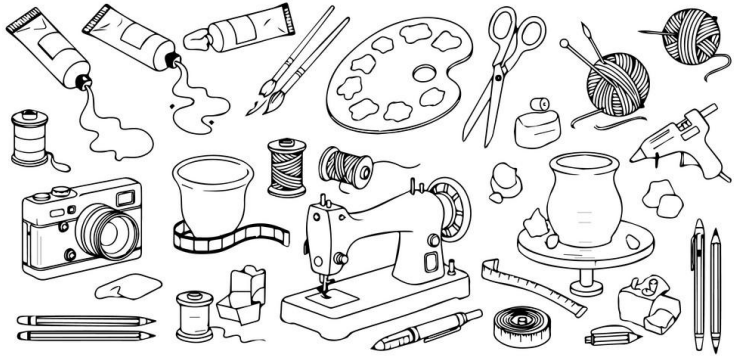


craft

/kraft/

noun

1. an activity involving skill in making things by hand.
   "the craft of bookbinding"



Understanding craft



Diverse participants are

Experience: beginners ↔ masters

Finance: hobby ↔ career

Frequency: low ↔ high

Barrier of Entry: easy ↔ hard

Extreme users are

Experience: beginners ↔ masters

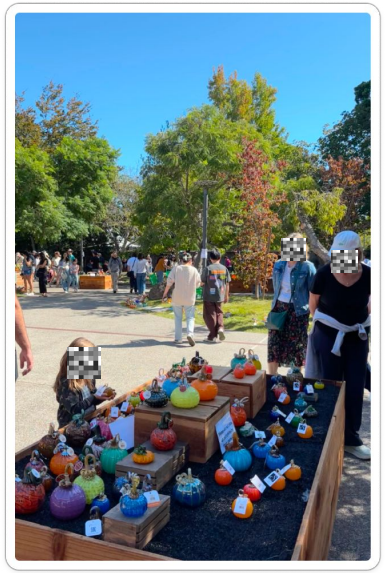
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We recruited by







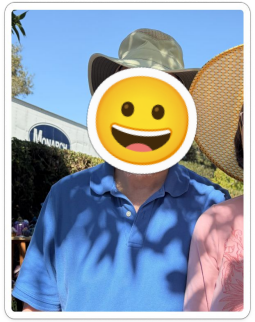


glass pumpkin patch @ south PA

We met

beginner crafter

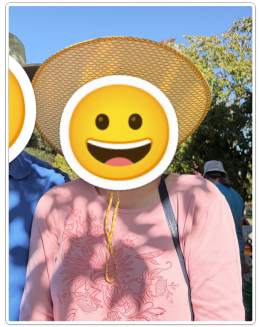
extreme crafters



An admirer becoming a maker



A hobbyist creating to unwind and connect



An experienced crafter choosing to begin again



A crafter who protects room for play



An artist who teaches and performs

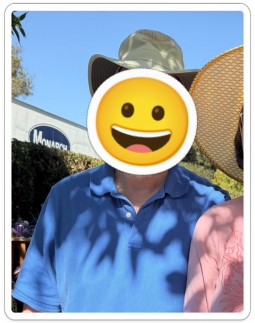


An artist balancing livelihood and discovery

We met

beginner crafter

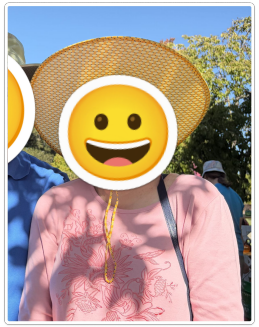
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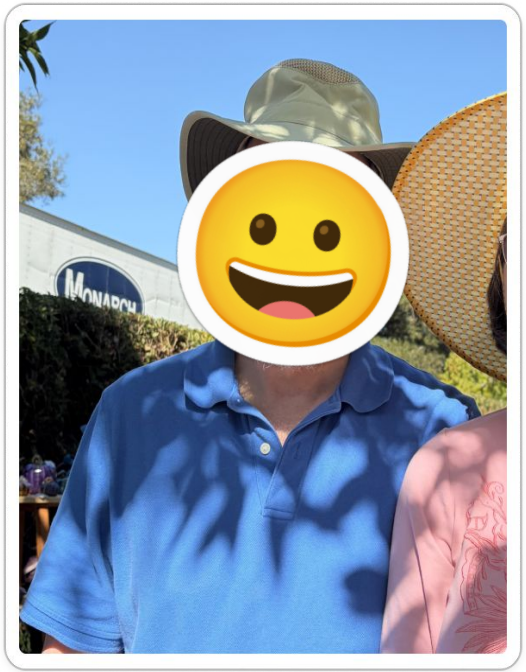
An artist who teaches and performs



An artist balancing livelihood and discovery

… and asked them





Eddy

An admirer becoming a maker

- Recently retired software professional
- Has admired and collected glass for decades
- Taken two glassblowing classes while traveling

“It’s an opportunity to do something new and fun”

"I used to take pictures of them and I haven't got all of them but she made some really cool ones and it's just a lot wow"

"we were just back there a month or two ago and this time I did a vase which actually has a little more involvement"

"Its so cool and expressive"

"They actually put a couple of her [quilts] in museums... they're like exhibits"

"If you stop learning, you're dead, so I never want to stop"

"Wouldn't it be neat to be able to make my own?"

"Yeah, there's time"

"One of my sayings is 'If you stop learning, you're dead', so I never want to stop"

"That's true, I do have more time now" [retired]

"It doesn't always come out the way you think it will either"

"Adventure + "Learning" in response to why they craft even when initially lacking confidence

"That kind of the spirit of discovery in a little way it is the same. You know, it's sort of on a different octave because we have so much history behind us by now, but it's still the same thing. It's a part of your head maybe you've never touched, a part of life experience you've never done, and all of a sudden it's a chance to. It's an opportunity to do something new and fun. Yeah, you can't argue with it."

"You never know what you're going to get"

Patted wife on the back, "I'm sure you'll do it" "There's always next week"

Says

Due to working a full time job, there isn't enough time to invest in the craft to create something they'd actually aspire to create

If you call yourself a crafter of something or regularly engage in the craft the way a "legitimate" crafter would, then you have to be good at said craft

The process of creating a craft is an adventure, Eric states he wants to adventure and yet he has taken so long to begin the adventure

Views crafts as an extension of ones self, a craft and the perceived quality of the craft says something about its crafter and that crafters capabilities/value perhaps

By returning to the same site where he first did glass blowing and attempting a more complex glass blowing piece, he thinks that he is building his skill in the craft

Since in a craft you are making the decisions that produce the results, he thinks that the craft you ultimately make is almost like a personal statement of sorts or an expression of one's self i.e. a craft SAYS something and isn't just for fun or for the heck of it, a craft has meaning tied to oneself

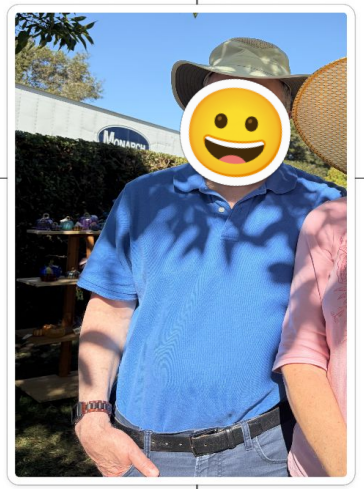
If he picks up the local classes, then the craft is more serious so he there is more pressure to perform well in the craft, whereas if he takes the classes while on trips/ vacations away from his regular routine, there is less pressure because everything within that trip is associated with "just for fun"

Similar to the saying "life is like a box of chocolates", I think Eric similarly views crafts in this way where crafts are like a box of chocolates, a mix of pleasant surprises, maybe you don't like some at all, but there is joy in experimenting, play, trying without knowing, and experiencing the journey + result

Because his software career trained him to expect that effort and experience make outcomes predictable, he's thrown by glass behaving like code that "doesn't always come out the way you think it will". mastery, he's realizing, doesn't guarantee control

Even after "buying it for years and years" and watching a master at work in Murano, he still insists he's "definitely a beginner", he draws a hard line between appreciating a craft and being skilled enough to call himself its maker

Thinks



Does

Provides partner a ton of encouragement

Has been buying the craft he longs to partake in for "years and years"

First did a flower glass blowing class at the museum

Returned to the same museum to do a vase "which actually has a little more involvement"

"Stalks" the local class offerings but has yet to take them

Watches "masters" and admires

Often thinks about viewers of the craft, how viewers perceive that craft and thoroby the person

Traveled to Murano to watch a master glassblower at work, to know "what to aspire to"

Has taken only "a couple of classes" total, despite admiring and collecting glass art for decades

Retired from his software career and now has "more time" to put toward glass

Feels

INTIMIDATED

[as an admirer]

FREEDOM TO PLAY

[as a beginner]

INSPIRED

[as an admirer]

PRIDE

EXPRESSIVE

CREATIVE

SURPRISE

DELIGHT

ADVENTURE

CHALLENGED

EDUCATED

DISCOVERY

GRATEFUL/APPRECIATIVE OF LIFE

TICKLED

EXCITED

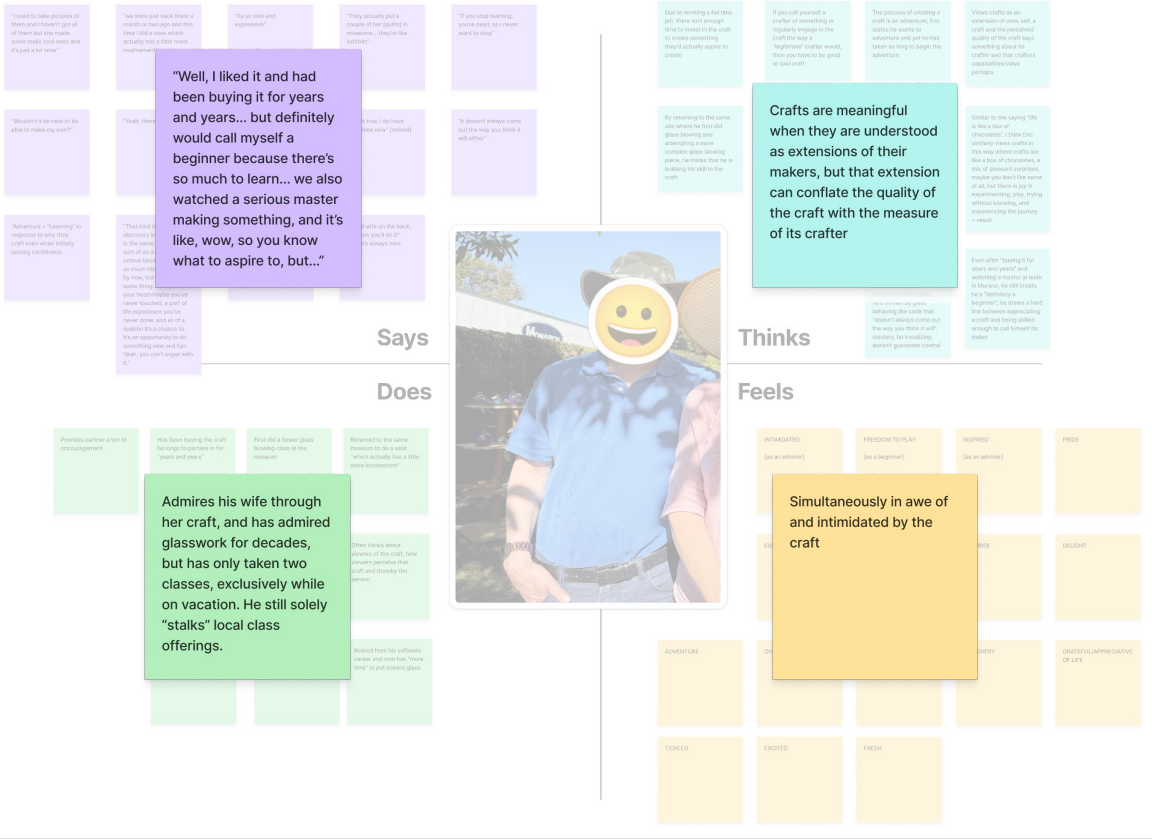
FRESH

Surprised to notice

Eddy tries crafting while traveling, yet hasn't made it part of his life back home

"I'm still stalking them [local glass blowing classes]"

"There's always next week"



Finding

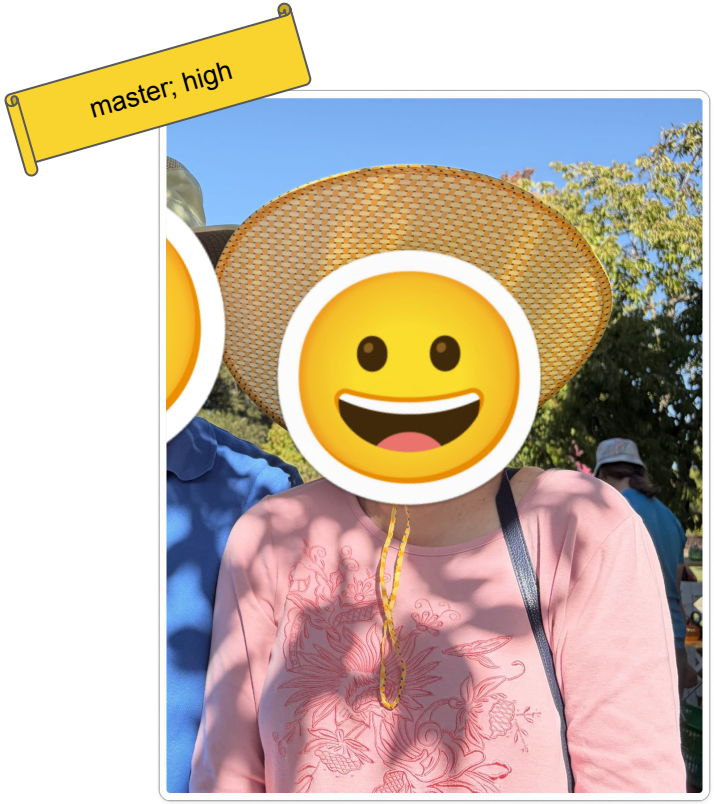
INSIGHT

Travel lets Eddy treat crafting as an **adventure** rather than a commitment to mastery. Calling himself a beginner **eases the pressure** to measure up to artists he admires



NEED

To experience crafting as an **adventure he can try**, without feeling he must **prove** an identity as a maker



Rosa

An experienced crafter choosing to begin again

- Retired nurse who has knitted for 60 years
- Makes around 30 quilts a year for children through a charity
- Became a beginner again through Japanese flower arranging

“I always want to have a tiny adventure with, you know, three flowers in a vase”

Says

"In my mind it's gonna look like this, and it never does."

I never want to be that person who doesn't look forward to some new experience.

I always want to have a tiny adventure with, you know, three flowers in a vase.

It's okay to try because if I mess up my flower arrangement, no one's going to die... it's voluntary.

My mother taught me to knit and she was not a critical teacher. She was very forgiving of all of the mistakes.

I feel confident about doing that because I've been doing it for 60 years now.

That oldest child sort of, you know, you better do it right, you know, everyone's watching you kind of a thing.

I'm like I don't think I can do this." ... "Sensei will fix it for me.

If I don't like the design or I don't like the colors I can change it.

I don't want to stall either. I want to keep going forward

"Did I follow all the rules" "strong (grasp) of the rules" before you can "go off from there"

Thinks

"Making it for a kid gives it a point." Belief: craft means most when it helps someone.

"Did I get it right?" Belief: as a beginner, being correct matters more than being creative.

"Only a master gets to break the rules." Belief: creative freedom is earned.

"If I mess up, no one's going to die." Belief: low stakes make it safe to try.

"Old people want to learn too." Belief: age is no reason to stop learning.

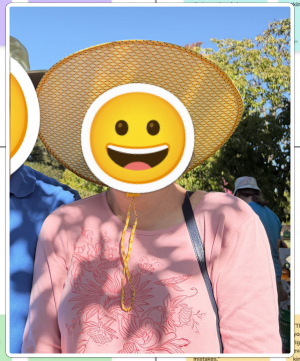
"First I copy what's right." Belief: imitation comes before invention. (This replaces your "inferred" sticky.)

"Sensei will fix it for me." Belief: a trusted teacher makes struggling safe.

"I can always change it." Belief: mistakes can be undone, so they aren't failures.

"I need a different perspective." Belief: to grow, you step outside

"It never looks like I pictured, and that's okay." Belief: surprise is part of



Does

Makes about 30 quilts a year for a charity; estimates a couple of hundred total over 40 years

Knits hats, scarves, slippers and washcloths for the same charity, and "for me too" ; has knit since age 7.

Takes weekly Ikebana classes (about 3 years) after years of self-taught Western arranging

Sizes quilts deliberately around the recipients (kids moving around)

Designed her own "strawberry thief" quilt around a fabric of mice stealing strawberries

Gets donated fabric and pulls ideas "from all kinds of places"

Offered to show a quilt without being asked: "Want to see a quilt?"

Corrected Eric that LAX "is not a museum"

Struggled to text a photo to a new number

mistakes."
-Knitting has been her oldest hobby: 60+ years, since she was 7. It's been such a long living hobby and her earliest feelings was being safe enough to do it because it was a forgiving environment
-> Feels Safe

That oldest child sort of, you know, you better do it right, you know, everyone's watching you kind of a thing."
-> Feels like she's being watched

I don't want to stall either. I want to keep going forward
-> Feels eager or driven

If I don't like the design or I don't like the colors I can change it.
->Feels a sense of autonomy

proud and surprised when a piece turns out different "but still pleasing"

nervous before a new lesson

purposeful giving quilts away

modest when praised

Trusting of her teacher: "Sensei will fix it for me"

Playful and adventurous: "a tiny adventure with three flowers in a vase"

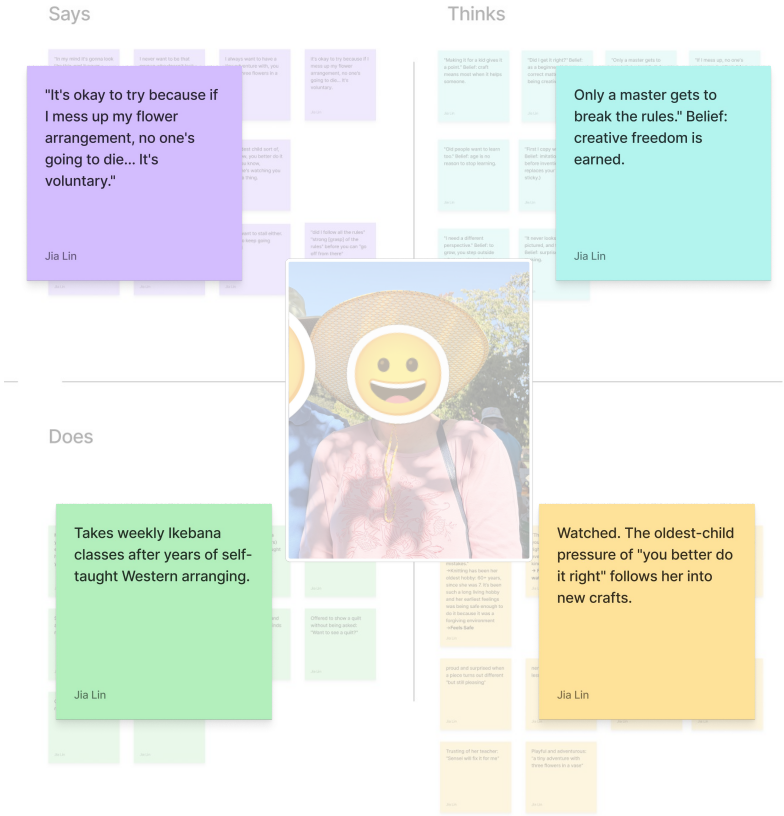
Surprised to notice

Rules that invite Rosa into a new craft can also make her hesitate to play within it

“First I copy what’s right”

“Sensei will fix it for me”

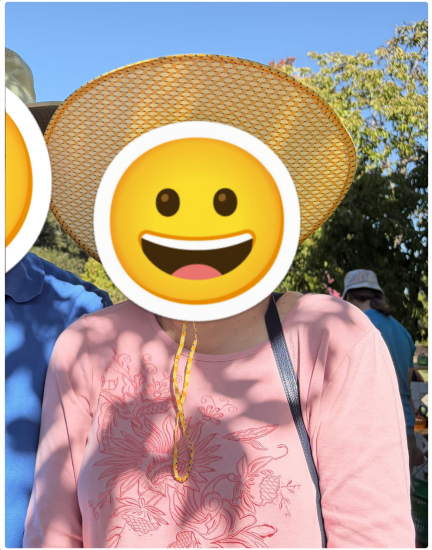
“But [the flowers] is pleasing. And then I worry, did I follow all the rules”



Finding

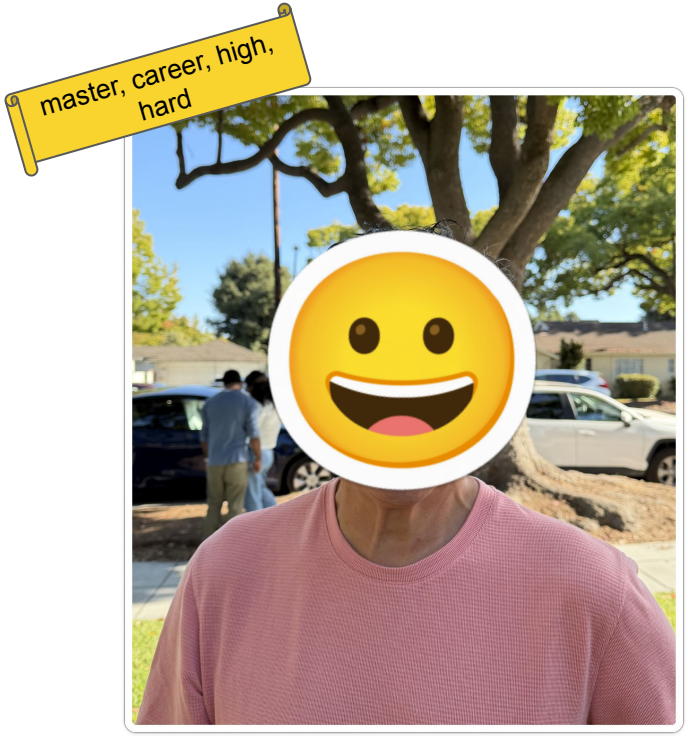
INSIGHT

Rules give Rosa a clear way into an **unfamiliar craft,** but they can shift her attention from enjoying what she discovers to checking **whether she did it correctly**



NEED

To feel that **creative freedom is hers to explore before mastery,** rather than a privilege she has to earn



Ken

A professional who protects room for play

- Professional neon artist and longtime glassblower
- Builds much of his own studio equipment
- Neon work funds his glassblowing experimentation

“I could just go in and play”

Says

"When glass is hot, the way it moves, it just is fluid."

"It is a real finicky process."

"I built a lot of my own equipment."

"It still fulfills that part of my brain in the technical side."

"I'm free to explore... the creative side."

"Pumpkins are my fun thing. Neon is sort of like my real job."

"Neon built my studio... it paid for everything."

"This is more fulfilling in a creative side."

"I have a very short attention span."

"I love working with my hands."

"I don't ever take notes about existing designs."

"I want to fulfill my desires to just try something different."

"I don't need to make every hour that I'm blowing glass successful financially."

"I have that freedom to just play."

"I just want to keep my studio going."

"I had been around art my whole life."

"Math and science... wasn't fulfilling in a creative side."

"I knew I was gonna get burned out on making neon signs."

"There's an infinite number of possibilities in blown glass."

"I don't rely on help."

Thinks

Independence gives him more freedom to create when inspiration or time allows.

Financial stability can create room for experimentation elsewhere.

Not every creative session needs to produce something profitable.

Pumpkins can function as a low-risk space for experimentation.

Variation is more interesting to him than perfectly reproducing past designs.

Challenge itself gives an activity value.

Rapidly switching between different kinds of glass work keeps him mentally engaged.

Difficult materials are appealing partly because fewer people are willing or able to master them.

A demanding task can create a kind of mental clarity.

Owning equipment expands what he is able to learn and attempt.

Sustaining the studio is necessary to sustain his creative freedom.

Learning new skills is part of what keeps his work meaningful.

Glass is uniquely compelling because the maker determines what an undefined molten material becomes.

Practical work and creative work can support each other even when they compete for time.

Commercial success is not his main measure of whether an experiment is worthwhile.

Creative fulfillment requires more than technical competence.

Endless possibilities make a craft more sustainable for him.

Repetition without novelty can eventually lead to burnout.

Technical and creative thinking do not need to be separate.

Glass blowing lets him combine his engineering mindset with artistic expression.



Does

Experiments more at the end of pumpkin season while he is already warmed up.

Moves between neon, pumpkins, quartz, light bulbs, ornaments, and other glass work.

Sometimes switches between very different glass types within minutes.

Takes on unfamiliar processes such as welding and metal casting.

Relies largely on word of mouth rather than an active digital presence.

Experiments with different glass color combinations.

Left engineering to pursue art.

Continued stained glass after learning it in high school.

Built a career making neon signs.

Began teaching neon after learning it quickly.

Pursued glass blowing after worrying about burnout from neon.

Built and has operated his own studio for decades.

Took glass classes in different places to expand his skills.

Works both independently and collaboratively.

Builds and designs much of his own equipment.

Troubleshoots furnaces and other studio equipment himself.

Uses pumpkins as a format for trying new techniques and colors.

Judges audience reactions to experimental pumpkin designs.

Starts each pumpkin season with new ideas rather than copying previous designs.

Avoids taking detailed notes that would make his designs perfectly repeatable.

Feels

Motivated by difficult tasks that few people can perform.

Focused when working with demanding materials.

Relaxed when a challenge requires his complete attention.

Proud of having the freedom and equipment to explore many different processes.

Drawn to the beauty, transparency, and unpredictability of glass.

Unfulfilled when work uses only his technical side without enough creativity.

Concerned about becoming burned out by repetitive work.

Excited by the endless possibilities of blown glass.

Fulfilled by working with his hands.

Fascinated by the transformation of glass from molten to solid.

Excited by trying something he has never done before.

Energized by combining engineering and artistic thinking.

Frustrated when equipment or furnaces fail unexpectedly.

Comfortable working independently.

Free when he can experiment without needing every piece to make money.

Creatively fulfilled by making pumpkins.

Financially dependent on neon work.

Frustrated when neon work crowds out time for glass blowing.

Pulled between the work that funds his studio and the work he finds creatively fulfilling.

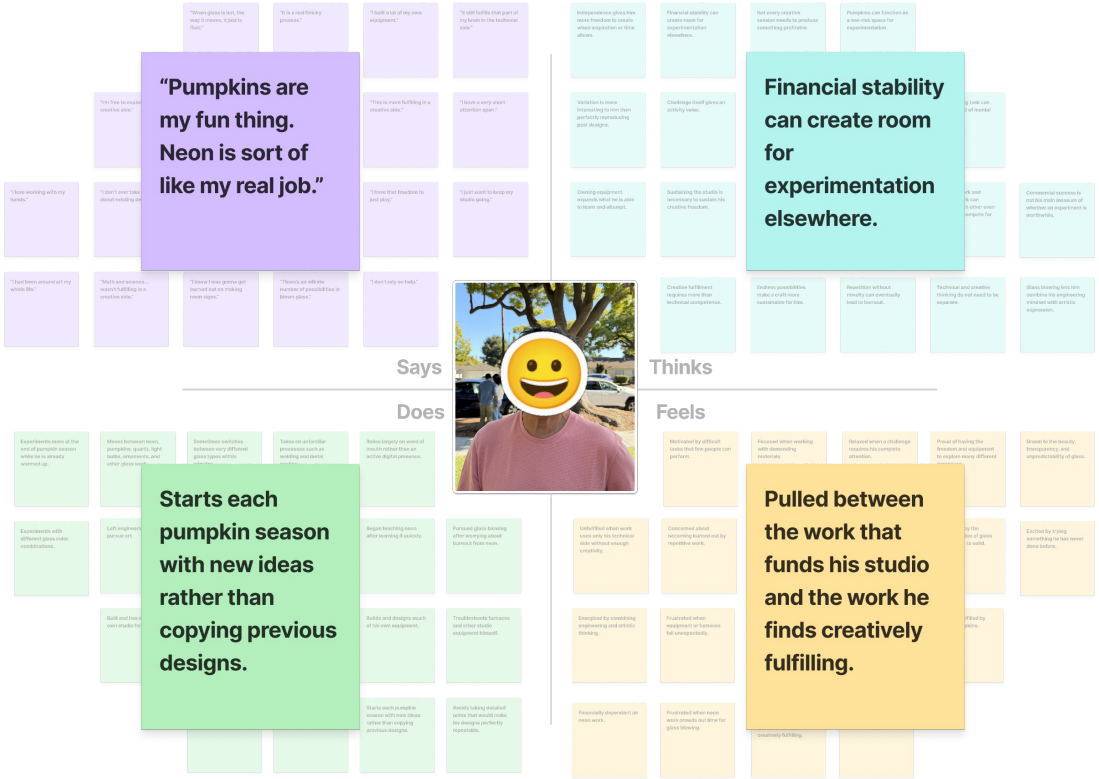
Restless when doing the same thing for too long.

Surprised to notice

Ken makes his living through one craft, yet turns to another to feel free to play

“I don’t need to make every hour that I’m blowing glass successful financially.”

“Pumpkins are my fun thing. Neon is sort of like my real job.”



Finding

INSIGHT

Neon supports his creative life, but its demands also compete with it. Glassblowing gives him room to **pursue unfamiliar ideas** without every **experiment needing to pay off**



NEED

To **protect opportunities for discovery** from the demands of the work that funds them



Noah

An artist balancing livelihood and discovery

- Self-employed glass artist for over 20 years
- Creates glass pumpkins and intricate sculptural pieces
- Balances reliable production with exploring original work

“I much prefer making my work and then selling it”

Says

"Once I gathered glass, I kind of fell in love with that process"

"The other work is more fulfilling because it's also more unique"

"When the furnace is running, you're spending money"

"The time that I spend doing this is limiting what I could do with my own art"

"There's only so much time and resources"

"I really pulled back on that side of my business because it's less fulfilling to me"

"The opposite of that is spending more time on something that feels more significant"

"This is something that still has the hand"

"That's my ultimate struggle, I can't make enough of either"

"I mainly use Instagram because it's the visual platform"

"I produce so many, and it's more of a volume production"

"I don't like to blow glass every day"

"I much prefer making my work and then selling it, rather than selling it and then making it"

"I like carrying the risk of whether someone will like it or not"

"It's nice, the community part of connecting with people and being part of this event"

"There's always a financial undertone to some of this"

"We were doing five hundred orders in a year"

"It really is never-ending. You find something new, a new possibility, and you want to keep scratching at that"

"The art is more pure that way, when you don't have a third party involved"

"I prefer coming out here, where you can be more creative"

"I got two instagrams, I get two storefronts"

Thinks

Digital visibility expands his audience but creates another business responsibility

Handmade work has special value in a mass-produced world

Meaningful work expresses a distinctive perspective rather than merely reproducing a product

Financial stability enables experimentation while also restricting it

Revenue-producing pumpkins protect the studio but compete with sculptural experimentation for time

Instagram suits glass because light, transparency, and texture need to be seen

Creative autonomy is a core measure of meaningfulness

Multiple brands reveal a divided identity—production artist, sculptor, and business owner

Business knowledge is essential to sustaining a creative career

Financial success and artistic meaning overlap but neither guarantees the other

Audience response matters most when it sparks wonder or a new way of seeing

Repetition can build mastery but excessive repetition diminishes meaning

Mastery comes through experimentation, repetition, and attention to material

Letting go of familiar work may be necessary to make ambitious work

Accessible work can be meaningful through community connection even when less artistically unique

Technical failure is something to understand and learn from

Constraints and small risks can open new artistic directions

Community impact and museum recognition are different but meaningful forms of success

Balance between meaning, connection, and revenue must be continually renegotiated



Does

Alternates hot glassblowing with slow cold grinding and polishing

Runs a studio with one full-time and two part-time employees

Starts with proven designs, then takes risks after inventory needs are met

Makes backup components for difficult commissions

Moves between twenty-minute pumpkins and coldworked pieces that take days

Produces approachable pumpkins for reliable revenue and community reach

Uses commissions to develop new techniques and ambitious forms

Carefully diagnoses failures instead of treating breakage as random

Explains glass through physical analogies such as gathering honey

Maintains separate Instagram accounts, websites, and storefronts for different work

Chooses in-person fairs to experiment and directly observe reactions

Pursues workshops and continuing craft education

Manages artistic, operational, marketing, and employment responsibilities

Consults Kevin on engineering challenges and shares troubleshooting knowledge

Pulled back from catalog sales despite high order volume

Adapts around power outages, equipment limitations, and studio access

Uses Instagram as his primary digital platform

Sells through art shows, his gallery, community pumpkin events, and previously catalogs

Feels

Proud when viewers' eyes light up or see differently

Fulfilled by community connection through approachable art

Pressured by furnace costs, deadlines, payroll, and successful execution

Responsible for sustaining employees and the studio

Grateful that pumpkins make art accessible and support his career

Hopeful about residencies, mobiles, and larger installations

Drained by replication, logistics, and matching catalog photographs

Overextended by multiple digital identities and storefronts

Excited by unplanned experimentation at in-person events

Calm and absorbed during meditative coldworking

Energized by the heat, motion, and possibility of molten glass

Intensely focused during hot work

Curious when material behaves unexpectedly

Divided between popular, secure production and distinctive sculptural work

Restless because production leaves too little time for experimentation

Vulnerable after investing substantial time in fragile work

Frustrated by breakage, outages, equipment demands, and unpredictability

Encouraged by Instagram's reach and visual immediacy

Uncertain whether closing a reliable revenue stream will create freedom or a harmful gap

Protective of creative freedom when clients or orders impose expectations

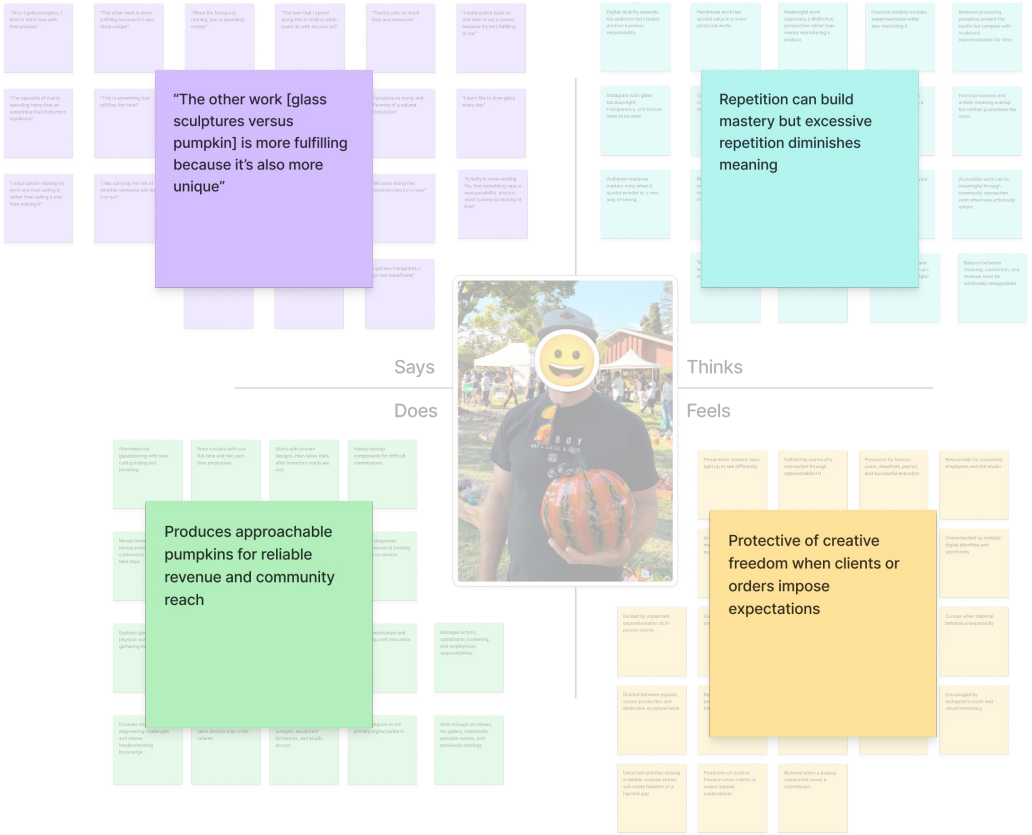
Relieved when a backup component saves a commission

Surprised to notice

Noah pulled back from successful catalogue work to make pieces he wasn't sure anyone would buy

"The other work is more fulfilling because it's also more unique"

"I really pulled back on that side of my business [catalogue work] because it's less fulfilling to me"



Finding

INSIGHT

Noah welcomes uncertainty when it leaves room for discovery.

Reproducing a promised result builds his skill, but experimenting helps him discover what he wants to **express as an artist**

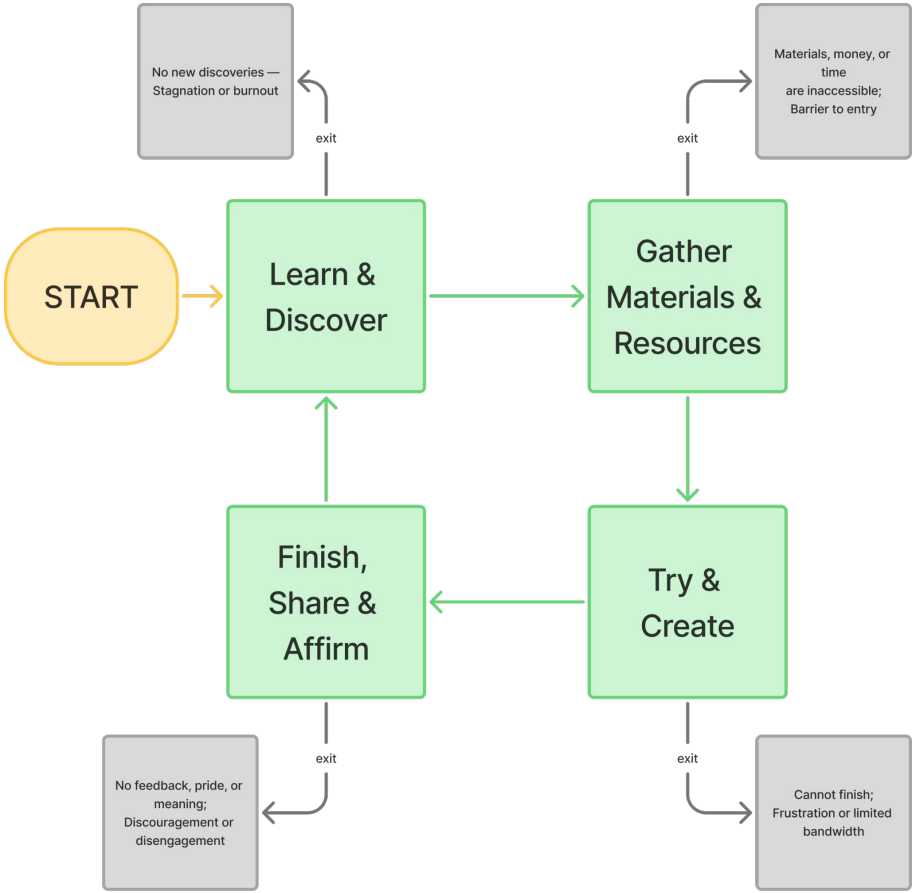


NEED

To let his **artistic voice evolve** beyond the work people already **expect from him**, while sustaining his livelihood

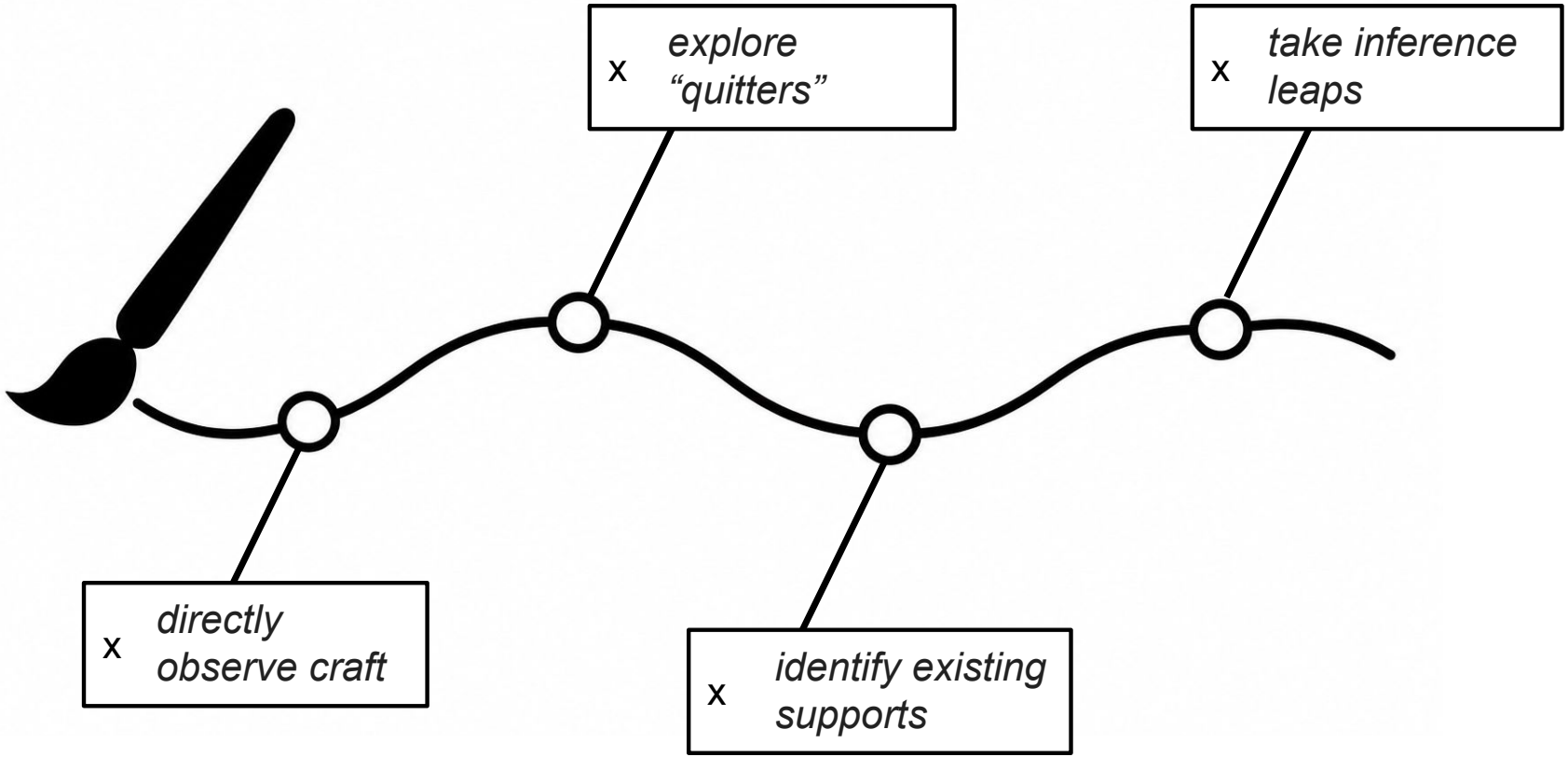
Why *choose* to be a beginner all over again?

“If you stop learning, you’re dead”


START
Learn & Discover
Gather Materials & Resources
Try & Create
Finish, Share & Affirm
exit
No new discoveries — Stagnation or burnout
exit
Materials, money, or time are inaccessible; Barrier to entry
exit
Cannot finish; Frustration or limited bandwidth
exit
No feedback, pride, or meaning; Discouragement or disengagement



Next Steps


x explore "quitters"
x take inference leaps
x directly observe craft
x identify existing supports

Thank you!

